

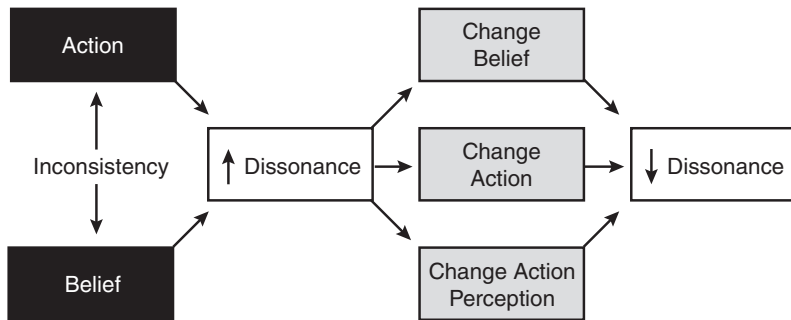


FIGURE 4.1 Cognitive Dissonance Theory

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lengths to convince themselves that the mobile phone they actually bought is better than the one they just learned about, to avoid mental discomfort associated with their initial purchase. In essence, they persist in their belief that they are correct. In that sense, cognitive dissonance bias is the basis for all of the belief perseverance biases in this section, with different variations on the same theme.

Technical Description

Psychologists conclude that people often perform far-reaching rationalizations in order to synchronize their cognitions and maintain psychological stability. When people modify their behaviors or cognitions to achieve cognitive harmony, however, the modifications that they make are not always rational or in their self-interest. Figure 4.1 illustrates this point.

Any time someone feels compelled to choose between alternatives, some sense of conflict is sure to follow the decision. This is because the selected alternative often poses downsides, while the rejected alternative has redeeming characteristics. These factors challenge the decision maker's confidence in the trade-off he or she has just negotiated. Commitment, which indicates an emotional attachment by an individual to the final decision, always precedes the surfacing of cognitive dissonance. If facts challenge the course to which a subject is emotionally attached, then those facts pose emotional threats. Most people try to avoid dissonant situations and will even ignore potentially relevant information to avoid psychological conflict. Theorists